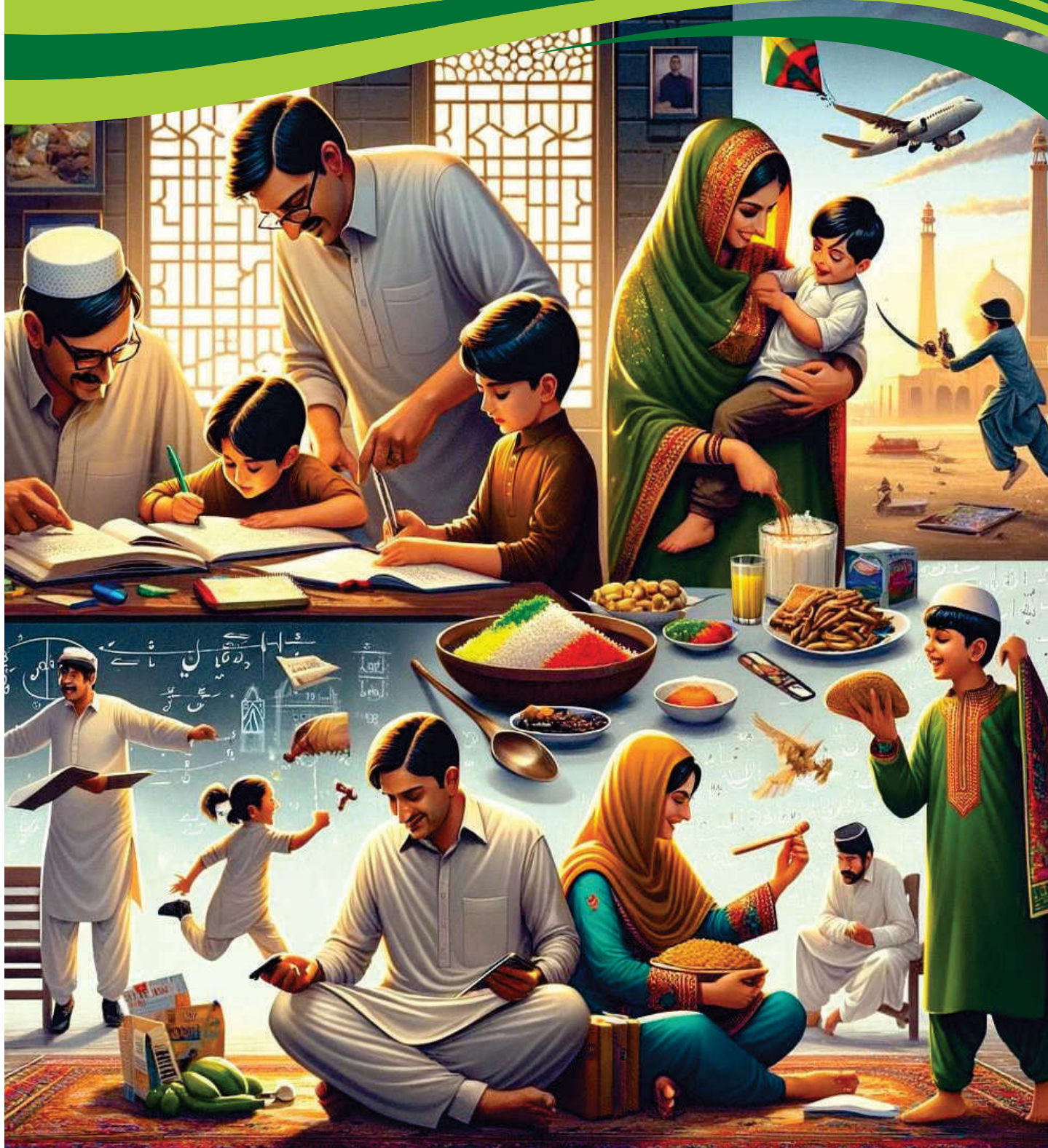


Module 3:

Embracing cultural diversity and gender inclusivity



Background

Parents should play their role in the holistic development of their children. A number of research studies indicate that there are several factors that contribute to the holistic and healthy development of a child. Amongst these are:

- Provision of encouragement, support, and access to activities that enable the child to master key developmental tasks.
- Instilling family values. Family is the main source of developing moral values in a child. Also, family values help develop children's mental and intellectual strength.
- Children learn about family bonding and mutual trust in families where there is a strong foundation of love.

Father and son relationship.

The Pakistani society is deeply influenced by cultural and traditional values. It has a patriarchal system, where males are predominately the bread-winners of the house. Fathers usually spend less time with children due to cultural norms and because they mostly struggle to manage work and family life. However, research has shown that father involvement is associated with better social-emotional behaviours in children; like how well a dad responds to a child's needs, rather than just the amount of time he spends with them.

Father and son share a special and unique bond. It is important for fathers to spend quality time with their boys because:

- Boys who have a good relationship with their fathers are less likely to have problems with the law when they grow up. Moreover, a good father can be a positive example for boys, helping them understand who they are and how to handle their feelings. Boys rely on their fathers for guidance, and consider them a model for how to behave in the world and in relationships.



- b) Research suggests that positive time spent with their fathers can reduce the likelihood of boys becoming anxious, depressed, or aggressive.
- c) Boys also crave warmth, affection, and tenderness from their fathers.
- d) Fathers matter right from the start. Children with fathers who are involved fathers from the beginning are more likely to feel secure, confident, and adventurous. They are likely to have healthy friendships as they grow up.

Father and daughter relationship.

In the Pakistani context, the religious and cultural values sometimes limit open communication between a father and daughter. This impact has been observed on daughters' self-esteem and their perspective regarding male authority. The involvement of fathers in their daughters' life can improve their overall psychological wellbeing. Research has shown that positive father and daughter relationship can:

- a) Inspire girls to be more independent and be successful in their respective career.
- b) Encourage them to make healthy choices when it comes to forming a relationship with male counterparts.
- c) Make them emotionally strong and they tend to have stable marriages
- d) Boost their self-esteem, and they are less concerned about their body weight and body image.
- e) Enable them to handle stress with resilience and become more strong emotionally and psychologically.



Mother and daughter relationship.

Mothers are the first contact of a child. Moreover, in Islam the role of a mother is highly emphasized and they are given a high status. Mothers are the primary caregivers and are held responsible for the upbringing of their children. The mother and daughter bond is very important in developing high self-esteem, resilience, and emotional stability in girls. Mothers act as primary role models, teaching their daughters basic skills, such as cooking, communication, and social behaviors, through daily interactions. A mother's way of managing household responsibilities, interacting with family

members, and dealing with stressful situations provides a blueprint for a daughter to follow. The mother daughter relationship is important as it helps girls

- a) To develop essential life skills and emotional resilience.
- b) To have a support system, where they can seek guidance
- c) To have a positive role model to follow

In Pakistan, daughters are often seen as a liability, because once they grow up they have to leave the house and also because “jahez” has to be prepared for their wedding. Hence, having a daughter is often quite stressful for both the parents. However, if a daughter has a strong and positive bond with her parents, it provides her a protective and supportive foundation throughout her life. Without this support, daughters often sacrifice their happiness and stay in toxic and unhealthy marriages, as parental backing is often not available. In some cases, parents may even pressure their daughters to put up with everything and stay silent to avoid societal pressure and the burden of providing financial and emotional support. Therefore, it is crucial for parents to educate their daughters and foster their financial and emotional independence, thereby ensuring that they can thrive, regardless of their marital circumstances.



Mother and son relationship.

In Pakistan, sons are preferred over daughters as they are expected to stay with their parents and be the future providers and protectors. This creates a lot of pressure on young boys; they have to be obedient and fulfil the responsibilities that their parents expect of them. Mothers are often perceived as pampering their sons, because they rely on them for support in their old age. Moreover, the bond a son has with his mother influences his future relationships and emotional stability. Sometimes, this emotional dependence can cause dysfunction in their marriages. Hence, it is crucial that mothers foster emotional independence in their sons, enabling them to make their own decisions. A positive and healthy mother-son relationship helps sons grow into individuals capable of balancing relationships and being both emotionally and financially supportive. It has been seen that boys having a positive relationship with their mothers are



- a) Emotionally more stable
- b) Make wise decisions; even as teenagers they do not engage in risk taking behavior
- c) Less likely to have substance abuse issues

Activity 3.1: Positive Parenting (30 minutes)

Objectives. The aim of this activity is to

- Introduce parents to the skills involved in positive parenting.
- Educate them about parenting styles, learned behaviors, and opportunities of growth in certain areas, while highlighting their existing strengths.
- Teach them how to share this information with others.

Resources.

- Color papers according to the number of participants
- Pencils and erasers

Activity steps and instructions.

1. Distribute color coded paper, eraser, and a pencil to each participant. Tell them that they have three minutes to draw a picture of their 'ideal' parent.
2. After three minutes, get volunteers to explain their picture; provide them positive feedback.
3. Next, ask the participants to find participants that have the same color paper as theirs and go to the spot in the room that has the same color paper (stick the sample color papers at a particular spot in the room in advance). Inform the participants that this is their team for the training session.
4. Then pose the following questions and ask them to discuss these in their group:

a. What is socialization?

Sample answers: Socialization is the process where an individual's standards, skills, motives, attitudes, and behaviors change to those regarded as desirable and appropriate in any particular society.

Socialization is the process by which children are prepared to become successful members of society.

b. Where does socialization take place?

5. Give them some time to discuss and then request a representative from each group to share their team's response. Provide feedback to each response.

6. Write the following question on the whiteboard:

What do you think is your role as a parent in the socialization and development of your child?

Tell the participants that this is simply a question for them to ponder on.

7. After a while, explain the role of parents in the development of a child.

- Socialization within the family is crucial in the development of a child, and when done in a positive manner, it equips the child with the necessary knowledge, skills, attitudes, and values.
- Parents and family are the first social groups that shape an individual's personality.
- From our families, we also inherit our position in the social structure.
- By looking at role models within the family unit (parents or siblings), children learn about the social role expected of them.

8. Then encourage volunteers to share their views on parents being socialization agents, and whether they are modeling for their child to be socially ready to be a productive member of the society.

9. Give examples of daily life, such as, if the father has a positive attitude towards any profession, any race, or any behavior the child adopts that too. Our cognitions and schemas are created from what we learn from the environment. A farmer's son is likely to have a positive attitude towards becoming a farmer, and a doctor's son towards becoming a doctor. The way the mother behaves with a certain group of people, the child is likely to imitate the same. Children learn from their parents; whether it is a skill or basic manners. Therefore, it is important, as a parent, to always be a positive role model in a child's life. (Facilitators should neither agree nor disagree with the participants' opinions).

10. Ask the participants to discuss in small groups their take away from the activity. Once they have discussed, invite a few participants to share these with the entire group.

11. The facilitator will ask the participants what they think about the roles and responsibilities of the family.

- Do they seem easy or hard to achieve? Why or why not?
- Do you believe that your own parents' parenting techniques have influenced the way you parent your child? Why or why not?

Learning outcomes. Parents will be educated on how socialization helps children learn to engage with others positively and appropriately. They learn how to take turns, share, and respect the feelings and boundaries of others. These skills are important in everyday life.

Notes for facilitators & follow-up actions by parents. Remind the parents to:

1. Lead by example
2. Play together
3. Join in activities
4. Take on projects
5. Listen non-judgmentally.
6. Be open to having sensitive/uncomfortable conversations.
7. Spend one-on-one quality time, with no distractions.
8. Connect them with spiritual or higher power, perform religious activities with them

Source Video Link

This video shall be played after or during the session:

<https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=yTFhcGGnVzA>

Socializing Process

The socialization process within the family has many components. Children learn moral values and social conventions through a process of socialization, much of which involves parenting. Socializing takes place in several ways:

1. *Normative*- through which the main social norms and rules are transmitted to the child;
2. *Cognitive*- through which the child acquires habits and knowledge necessary for action as an adult;
3. *Creative*- through which the capacities of creative thought and of giving proper responses in new situations are formed;
4. *Psychological*- through which the affectivity necessary for building relationships with parents, future partners, their own children, and with other persons is formed.

Child Rearing and Culture

Childrearing practices impact a child's development. These practices are influenced by a pattern of raising children that is specific to a particular society, subculture, family, or period in cultural history. Moreover, child-rearing practices vary with regard to methods of discipline, expression of affection, and degree of flexibility and tolerance.

Culture helps parents in constructing parenting roles; it influences parental thoughts, which, in turn, shape parenting practices. Moreover, culture is maintained and transmitted by one generation to the next. Many beliefs, values, habits, and thought patterns are ingrained through early family life. Economic resources also have a significant impact on parenting.



Culture-specific influences on parenting begin long before children are born; they shape fundamental decisions about which behaviors parents would promote in their children and how they would interact with their children. Also, in our part of the world, living in a joint family system is very common, with multiple generations living together. This strengthens the bond between the grandparents, the extended family members, and the children.

Islam and our culture place great importance on respecting and honoring grandparents, and their opinions are highly valued when making a decision. In many families' grandparents also serve as caregivers, when parents are working or are abroad. They not only support the child emotionally and physically but, sometimes, financially as well. However, at times, adolescents might struggle between the values and traditions being taught by their grandparents and the modern technology and its influences. Also, the ageing of grandparents with many health issues can also be challenging for both adolescents and other family members to deal with.

Activity 3.2: Importance of Family in a Child's Life (15 minutes)

Objectives. By the end of the activity the parents will be able to analyze the role of culture, norms, and traditions in raising children, and how the family norms and values influence children's behavior and practices.

Resources.

- Papers and Pencils for each participant

Activity steps and instructions.

1. Distribute different color papers to all the participants.
2. Ask them to write one thing they approved and one thing they disapproved that their children did, and why? Then ask each participant to write two sentences describing what the child did in both instances, for which they have two minutes.
3. Once they have done so, ask them to form a circle holding their papers in their hands. Request the participants to share their scenarios and have a whole group discussion.
4. Then ask the participants to find other participants that have the same color paper as theirs and go to the spot in the room that has the same color paper (stick the sample color papers at a particular spot in the room in advance). Inform the participants that this is their team for the training session.
5. Pose the following questions and ask them to discuss these in their group:
 - As a child, what was the one thing you wanted to do, but your parents' culture did not allow you to do?
 - As a parent, what things do you not allow your child/ children to do because of your cultural beliefs?
 - Do you believe that your parents' culture influenced the way they reared you and does it influence the way you raise your children?
6. Give them some time to discuss and then request a representative from each group to share their team's response. Provide feedback to each response.
7. Have a whole group discussion on these questions.

Learning outcomes: Parents will recall their parents' learning styles and will be able to look at their own learning styles and how these were evolving with their new learnings. They will realize that trainings like these are opportunities for growth, both for the parents and the children.

Notes for facilitators & follow-up actions by parents.

Steps to strengthen the parent-children relationship. Remind the participants that the parents need to do the following

1. Explore common interests.
2. Get involved in parent-child activities.
3. Schedule one-on-one time, or collectively with children, even if for a short period.
4. Prioritize spiritual formation of children with patience, love, and care

Activity 3.3: Child Rearing Practices (15 minutes)

Parents have different ways of expressing their love for their children and have their own way of rearing their children. The overall aim is to educate on how child-rearing practices affect child development, ways to set limits ways to discipline children without (inflicting physical pain nor emotional pain) beating them or shouting at them, and how to make the experience of parenting more joyful & less stressful. They will also learn how to share this information with others.

Objectives. The aim of this activity is to let parents reflect on the different child rearing practices and its impact on children

Resources. Flashcards with following scenarios written on it.

Scenario 1: Ali, a young boy, lives with his parents, grandparents, uncles, aunts, and cousins in a large family house. Sometimes he complains of not getting proper space where he can study.

Scenario 2: Ahmed and Ayesha are siblings. Ahmed is encouraged to play outside and be physically active, while Ayesha is often guided towards helping with household chores.

Scenario 3: Hina's parents insist she pursue a career in medicine despite her strong passion and talent for art and design. They believe becoming a doctor is the only path to a successful and respected future, ignoring her personal aspirations.

Activity steps and instructions.

1. After reading the scenarios. Ask participants to reflect on it.
2. Let participants discuss with each other about what they think about the scenarios.
3. Ask participants whether they have gone through similar situations? What are their thoughts?
4. How their child rearing practise impacts their child?

Learning outcomes. By the end of the session, the participants will be able to reflect and learn the different ways that can

Notes for facilitators & follow-up actions by parents.

- a) Stay informed about modern parenting practices and be willing to adapt traditional methods to better suit the child's needs in the contemporary context.
- b) Teach cultural and religious values in a way that is inclusive and respectful of the child's individuality and other perspectives.
- c) Encourage critical thinking and discussions about cultural and religious teachings to help children develop a well-rounded understanding
- d) Provide equal opportunities and encouragement to both boys and girls in all aspects of life, from education to extracurricular activities.
- e) Encourage children to explore various interests and talents alongside their academic pursuits. Provide opportunities for extracurricular activities that align with their passions.

Role that “Gender” Plays in Families

New evidence is emerging that confirms what parents and children have reported for generations, which is, that boys and girls behave differently, and parenting practices vary depending on the gender of the child. With time spent on gendered household tasks, and by observing the behaviours of their parents, teachers, and members of the society, at large, children learn about gender appropriate behaviours.

These behaviors are taught based on the expectations that society has from both men and women. However, because these are learnt, they can change over time, and can be different from society to society and generation to generation. Nonetheless, they have a powerful influence over how we live our lives and how these are conveyed to the next generation.



Parents can play a vital role in changing the society, by doing away with the prescribed roles and expectations from boys and girls, and replacing them with meaningfully engaging roles that provide equal opportunities to both, so that women and men can be equal partners in national development. They can become positive role model, by challenging gender stereotypes. For example, fathers can participate in picking up things scattered all over the house, at times, or in cleaning up the mess when the house help is not available. On the other hand, mothers can play outdoor sports with the children or take more interest in finances.

Gender characteristics shape (and are also shaped by) relationships between women and men. For example, cooking and house chores are usually considered as responsibilities of women; while men are expected to work outside and bring money. This is learnt and observed by adolescents and they tend to follow the same. In Pakistan, gender roles are based on a combination of traditional roles and social values.

Gender norms are still regressive in the Pakistani society. Forty percent of the women need permission from a family member to seek or retain employment, according to the 2019 Pakistan Social and Living Standards Measurement survey. Over 80 percent women think that they should be allowed to work. One potential avenue for improving gender equality is through addressing "misperceived" norms.

Families are the first teachers; therefore, it is necessary that parents become aware that the way boys and girls are raised is what contributes to the gender inequalities and inequities that are visible in our society today. Parents should realize that their role is crucial in changing these expectations and behaviors from an early age, so that girls may be accorded opportunities for equal participation and access to resources, for maximizing their full potential as young and adult women.

Children learn at a young age that there are distinct expectations for them, based on their sex. Studies reveal that children are aware of gender roles by the age of two or three; at four or five, most children are firmly entrenched in culturally appropriate gender roles. Parents often supply male children with trucks, toy guns, and superheroes, like Spiderman etc., which are active toys that promote motor skills, aggression, and solitary play. Female children are often given dolls and dress-up apparel, which fosters nurturing, social proximity, domestic skills, and role play.

Activity 3.4: Gender Norms and Parenting (15 minutes)

Objectives. By the end of the session, participants will be able to reflect on the influence of gendered expectations in family life, and to explore adolescent social and cognitive development.

Resources.

- Pens, markers or crayons, and extra papers
- Flipcharts, with definitions of gender, gender roles, gender stereotypes, and sex

Key concepts.

Gender Identity: It is one's perception or sense of being male or female or other.

Gender Roles: Expectations of men and women's behavior and their prescribed roles in society

Gender Stereotype: An oversimplified or biased description of the abilities of men and women in terms of their behavior, roles etc.

Sex: The physical characteristics that make an individual male or female

Activity steps and instructions.

1. Explain that within the family, girls, women, boys, and men may have different responsibilities. Some examples of situations are:
 - a. One caregiver is responsible for caregiving responsibilities, while the other caregiver earns money.
 - b. Both caregivers work and share the caregiving responsibilities.
 - c. One caregiver is expected to take the caregiving responsibilities and to earn an income, while the other caregiver is only responsible for earning an income.
 - d. There is a primary caregiver, and older girls or young women share responsibilities for taking care of younger children.
 - e. There is a primary caregiver and older boys are expected to earn an income.
 - f. There is a primary caregiver who is present, and the family relies on a member who is not present to provide economically.
2. Start the activity. Read out each of the above statements and ask the participants who agree with

the statement “to raise their hands”, and those who do not agree with these statements “not to raise their hands”. Get a rough idea of how many hands were raised in favor or against the statements.

3. Next, based on their reactions, ask the participants the following questions and discuss:

- a. Do any of these situations sound familiar to you? Which ones?
- b. Are there any situations described above that you do not agree with or where the responsibilities could be different?
- c. How are expectations for members of families now similar or different from when you were a child?
- d. How do families decide who should take care of children or other household responsibilities and who should earn money?
- e. If both caregivers are working, who do you think should be responsible for caregiving? Is this similar or different from real-world situations?

[Women might say that it is not a man’s role to help with the household responsibilities, and that they think they would not do a good job, or they do not want their help. Facilitators should probe as to why women feel this way and whether in some situations it could be helpful for men to support in these tasks.]

4. Variation of the activity. Participants can be asked to stand in a circle and with every statement that they agree/resonate with, they step forward and then step back to their space. This is repeated with every statement that is read out.

(Tell the participants that we, as parents, are sharing a safe place here, with no judgements, and all of us are here to validate some of our parenting responsibilities, whether we are carrying them out well, while learning through new opportunities of growth for ourselves and our children)

5. Tell the participants that rules set limitations on a person and on how they can behave, act, or what they can achieve. For example, it may not be considered ‘normal’ for a man to cook for the family, while the woman goes to work. But when the situation is difficult, women and men may see a shift in their roles. For example, a woman may need to be the main provider for the family in situations where this was traditionally seen as a man’s role. However, while some women may be able to negotiate responsibilities with their partners, some are unable to do so because they have limited decision-making power in the household. Girls and boys observe and learn to follow these rules early, based on

early, based on what they see, and what their families and others tell them.

7. Now, ask the following questions:

- Does this sound familiar to anyone?
- Has anyone experienced dealing with this kind of a situation?
- Around what ages do you think girls and boys start taking on more responsibilities at home?
- How do their responsibilities differ?
- How do family's expectations from girls and boys change/differ with their age?

Learning outcomes: Parents will be able to reflect on how society can place different expectations or limitations on the roles that women, girls, boys, and men play inside and outside the home. These become a set of rules. Parents can promote gender roles that are not according to the society, but after sharing the reasoning with the child and listening to the reasoning shared by them.

Notes for Facilitator & follow-up actions by parents:

What Children Want

Children want to be:

Free: Give some freedom with precautions to adolescents so that they can express themselves

Loved. Express affection often, through your words, actions, and mutual respect.

Seen and valued. Acknowledge their importance by involving them in decision-making within the family.

Heard and connected. Create an open environment, without judgment, to make the children feel heard and emotionally connected.

Appreciated and encouraged. Respond with praise and encouragement to make children feel appreciated for their contributions

It is important to remember that no one strategy will be effective in every situation, or with every child. However, the more options for guidance and discipline that parents have to choose from, the more successful they will be in meeting the challenges of living and working.

Activity 3.5: Break the Stereotype (20 minutes)

Objectives. This activity aims to break the stereotypes that people usually have, brainstorm the gender roles given by society, and how these stereotypes can be challenged.

Resources.

- Flashcards with different riddles related to gender.

Activity steps and instructions.

1. Participants will be given a riddle to see if they understand the concept of gender and sex; as this riddle is circulated, some parents may get it quickly. the riddle id as follows:
 “A father and son are in a horrible car crash that kills the father. The son is rushed to the hospital just as he is about to go under the knife, the surgeon says, “I can’t operate. That boy is my son!”
2. Discuss possible answers. The answer is ‘The doctor is the mother of the boy.’
3. Depending on how quickly the participants get it, explain that the immediate answer that is likely to come to mind is that “How could the boy be the son of the doctor because the father had died in the accident?” This is because our minds are somewhat so tuned culturally that we are likely to see only males as doctors, particularly as surgeons. Hence, it is difficult for us to see women as surgeons. Therefore, the first thought that comes to mind is: “How could the boy be the son of the doctor because the father had died in the accident?”
4. Next, pair up participants (one male/one female, if possible) and ask them to brainstorm the stereotypes that we have of boys and girls and men and women, and to discuss how this stereotyping affects them. For example: Girls don’t climb trees, boys don’t cry, girls do dishes, boys take out garbage, etc., men are the income earners, while women take care of the house and babies, and how these roles come about. Some examples of consequences could be: domestic violence, less pay for women, men having multiple partners, because men have to maintain their “Macho” image.
5. Once they have discussed, ask all the pairs to present a brief summary of their discussions.
6. After this sharing of ideas, ask the participants to think about ways to change the way we go about raising children so that our child rearing practices become more inclusive for boys and girls. For example, explain that, as parents, they can allow the boys and girls to engage in any

that a boy will not be less of a boy if he washes dishes, and a girl less of a girl if she climbs activity. By giving them both the same opportunities, they will be subtly conveying the message that a boy will not be less of a boy if he washes dishes, and a girl less of a girl if she trees. We often prevent them from becoming all that they can be by locking them into prescribed expectations and career choices. We don't allow boys to play with dolls because they will become "sissies" and by doing this we are minimizing their role as a father – when they become one – as a consequence, he will not take the desired role in raising his own child because he didn't learn to do so.

Ask participants to come up with examples, if any, of changes we see in the expectations and behaviors of men and women and how they as parents can continue to contribute to these positive changes today. For example – men taking children to day care, more women running for political office etc. maybe some of their answers.

Learning outcomes: Via this activity parents will hopefully reflect on how common gender-based violence or inequality is inflicted or accepted on daily basis without noticing it or being intentionally malicious.

Notes for facilitators & follow-up actions by parents.

1. Encourage children to pursue their interests and talents, regardless of gender norms.
2. Help them build confidence and self-esteem so they can stand up against discrimination and violence.
3. Share household responsibilities equally among all family members, regardless of gender.
4. Show children that caregiving, chores, and decision-making are shared responsibilities.
5. Educate children about the importance of consent and respecting personal boundaries from an early age.
6. Make sure they understand that it's okay to say no and that they should respect others' right to do the same.

Gender Based Violence and Parenting

Why is it important to examine our socio-cultural beliefs and practices that define gender roles and expectations? Because the existing gender inequality leads to gender-based violence. Gender Based violence occurs to perpetuate gender norms and expectations that facilitate men's social, economic and political power, and control of, and access to, resources. Despite some advances with regard to women's rights in Pakistan, economic and political unrest has increased gender-based violence in the country.

Gender-based violence is prevalent in Pakistan, in various forms such as verbal abuse, physical assault, sexual violence, including rape and forced sex. Unfortunately, these incidents are often regarded as private matters, with legal action rarely taken. Additionally, honor killings, known as Karo Kari, are witnessed, these are justified as



actions taken in the name of honor. Other forms of gender-based violence include practices like bride price, (where money is demanded by the bride's family, from the groom's family, in return for which the girl is given away in marriage), Watta Satta (a simultaneous marriage arrangement a brother-sister pair from one households), marries a brother-sister pair from another household), Vani (where girls, often minors, are given in marriage as compensation to resolve disputes), and marriage with Quran (where girls are married off to the Quran to control their property rights). Furthermore, women are often discouraged or barred from pursuing political careers.

Activity 3.6: Children Rights and Laws versus Social Norms (20 minutes)

Objectives. After this activity the parents will be able to identify gender violence, its impact, and how to help their children protect themselves from gender-based violence.

Resources.

- Sheets of paper with the GBV Venn wheel

Activity steps and instructions.

1. Give a sheet with the GBV Venn wheel to each participant and ask them to individually reflect on the following points:

- Violence used against me.
- Violence that I used against others.
- Violence that I have witnessed.
- How I feel when I use violence.
- How I feel when violence is used against me.

2. After a few minutes, guide group discussions on the following topics:

- What is the most common type of violence used against women?
- What is the most common type of violence used against men?
- How do you feel when you use violence against others?
- How do you feel when violence is used against you?
- How does the media (music, radio, movies) portray violence?
- What is the link between violence in your families and relationships and other acts of violence that you see in your communities?

Learning outcomes: This discussion will help them reflect on gender-based violence and learn how to minimize it.

Notes for facilitators & follow-up actions by parents. Tell the parents that through following actions they can play a role in overcoming gender based violence.

- a. **Promote gender equality.** Encourage equality and respect between genders within the family. Model egalitarian behaviors and challenge prescribed gender roles and stereotypes.
- b. **Open communication.** Foster open communication with your children about relationships, boundaries, consent, and respect. Create a safe environment, where they feel comfortable discussing sensitive topics.
- c. **Educate about consent.** Teach your children about the importance of consent in all types of relationships. Help them understand what healthy relationships look like and emphasize the necessity of mutual respect and communication.
- d. **Monitor media consumption.** Be mindful of the media your children consume, including TV shows, movies, music, and social media. Discuss with them how media portrayals can influence perceptions of gender roles and relationships.
- e. **Address bullying and harassment.** Take reports of bullying, harassment, or disrespectful behavior seriously. Teach your children to stand up against gender-based bullying and to support those who are targeted.
- f. **Teach emotional intelligence.** Help your children develop emotional intelligence by encouraging them to recognize and manage their emotions in healthy ways. This can reduce the likelihood of resorting to violence as a means of expressing frustration or anger.
- g. **Promote empathy.** Encourage empathy and perspective-taking by discussing the experiences and feelings of others. Teach your children to consider how their actions may impact others and to intervene when they see injustice or harm.
- h. **Provide positive role models.** Expose your children to positive role models who exemplify healthy, respectful relationships and non-violent conflict resolution.

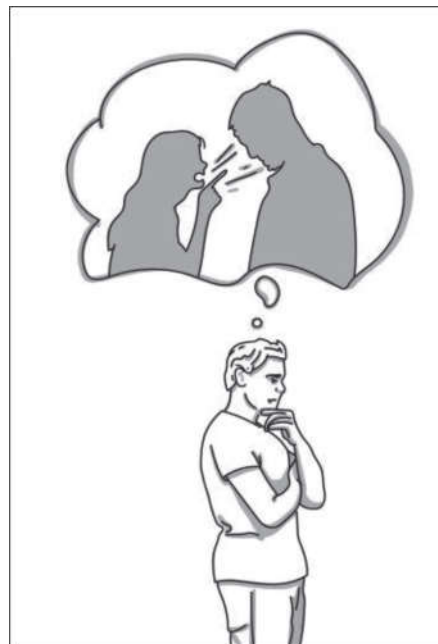
This video shall be played before or after the session:

<https://youtu.be/4v5JTOpEJRE?si=nDLeQDygw97JrGie>

Gender Rights in Pakistan

There is a list of 30 basic rights and protections for every single human being in the world called the Universal Declaration of Human Rights, agreed upon by the global community of states, through the United Nations. They are things we need in order to thrive and participate fully in society; they can be rights to have something positive, as well as rights to be free from something negative. These rights include, but are not limited to:

- Equal treatment under the law
- Availability of food, water, shelter, and clothing
- Being treated with respect and dignity
- Freedom of expression
- Freedom of thought, conscience, and religion
- The right to assemble and to participate in society
- The right to education
- The right to health, including access to health information and service



Gender inequality poses a significant human rights issue in Pakistan, affecting a considerable segment of the female populace. Approximately half of the Pakistani women face barriers to obtaining basic education, and disparities in health and nutrition. Additionally, numerous women find themselves constrained within their homes, lacking the freedom to make decisions impacting their well-being and family life. In contrast, men wield considerable influence in the Pakistani society, leading to the marginalization of women and negative consequences for them across different life stages.

According to one of the case studies, there is a prevailing belief among certain communities that Muslim women should be raised to fulfill traditional roles as dutiful daughters, wives, and mothers, with education seen as being potentially disruptive in the fulfilment of these roles. It is argued that educated girls may become less obedient and less inclined to engage in household duties, which are

deemed their primary responsibilities. Furthermore, religious leaders, who are particularly influential in rural areas, sometimes misinterpret Islamic teachings to discourage education for women. They propagate the idea that education leads to independence, which could compromise a woman's ability to fulfill her familial roles effectively. These teachings often serve as obstacles to girls' education.

Additionally, practical barriers, such as limited access to educational facilities and concerns about women's safety, contribute to the reluctance of parents to send their daughters to school. Many schools are located far away, and the co-education system, viewed as contrary to Islamic principles by some, further dissuades parents from allowing their daughters to pursue education out of fear for their safety.

Importance of Parental Involvement in a Child's Education

Several researches indicate that there are many factors that contribute to the holistic and healthy development of a child. One significant factor is education. Parents' involvement has far-reaching effects on a child's academic performance. How can parents contribute in their children's education? Here are some of the ways:

- a. Parent's engagement has been measured in many ways. Their presence in school meetings, sports day events, and school events, particularly those in which their child's achievements are recognized and rewarded.
- b. An important role of a parent is to provide encouragement, support, and access to activities that enable the child to master key developmental tasks
- c. Children with parents who are involved in their school tend to have fewer behavioral problems and better academic performance, and are more likely to have a higher level of academic success than children whose parents are not involved. Parents of high-achieving students set higher standards for their children's educational activities than parents of low-achieving students



Activity 3.7: Parents' Responsibility to Educate Their Children (20 minutes)

Objectives. This activity aims to make parents reflect on the importance of every child's right to basic education.

Resources.

- Prints of the given scenario for each participant

Impact of parents' lack of involvement in children's education: Nine-year-old Marium wakes up at four every morning. She does not go to school, but goes to sell bangles at the railway station of Sukkur. Her parents do not see the need for her to stay in school, as they believe she can help the family by bringing in money to help with the family needs. In fact, her parents were never interested in her schooling. Marium, who has seven younger brothers and sisters, barely completed grade 1.

Activity steps and instructions.

1. Give a copy of the scenario to all the participants.
2. Divide them in groups of 4/5 and ask them to discuss the following questions in their groups:
 - a. What is taking place in the scenario?
 - b. Is it alright for Marium to be out of school?
 - c. What will happen to Marium in the future?
3. Once they have discussed, present the following information:

Benefits of parental involvement in education.

Benefits for the children. Children whose parents are involved in their education

- tend to achieve more, regardless of ethnic or racial background, socioeconomic status, or parents' education level
- generally achieve better grades, test scores, and attendance
- consistently complete their homework
- have better self-esteem, are more self-disciplined, and show higher aspirations and motivation toward school

Benefits for the parents. Parents who are involved in their children's education generally

- Increase their interaction and discussion with their children and are more responsive and sensitive to their children's social, emotional, and intellectual developmental needs

- Are more confident in their parenting and decision-making skills
- Have improved perceptions about the school, and stronger ties with and commitment to the school
- Are aware of policies that affect their children's education
- Choose to be more active when requested by the child's school to be a part of the decision-making team.

Parents' Role in Their Children's Education. What should the parents do to support their children in their education? They can

- Play an active role as parents in their child's schooling
- Appreciate the uniqueness of each child, respect and respond to the child's feelings, needs, and interests
- Teach the children to manage their behavior in a constructive manner and tell them what acceptable behavior looks like and why? Have a discussion. It is better if the children come up with solutions, as it builds confidence and gives them a reason to live up to their own expectations.
- Provide materials and share experiences to learn from, and find time to be involved with your children

Learning outcomes. This activity will enable parents to reflect on the importance of every child's right to basic education and their crucial role in providing them good education.

Notes for facilitators & follow-up actions by parents. Ask the parents to do the following:

1. Create a home environment that encourages learning.
2. Express high (but not unrealistic) expectations for their children's achievement and future careers.
3. Become involved in their children's education at school and in the community.
4. Take an active role in their child's education by ensuring that they do their homework, and that they go to school on time.
5. Visit the school to check on their progress,

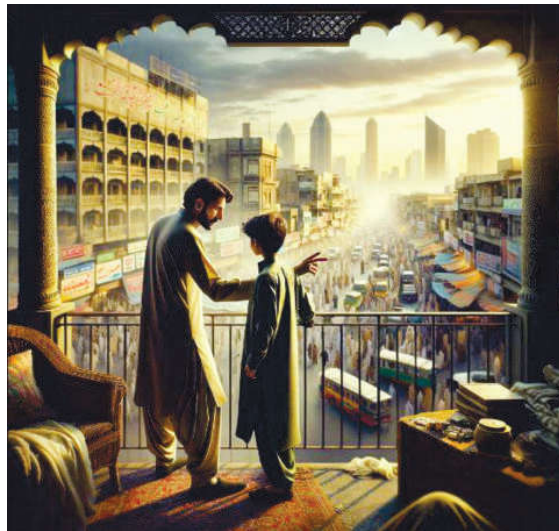
6. Attend Parent Teachers' Meetings (PTA)
7. Participate in and support their child in extra- curricular activities, such as talent shows, field trips, sports day, etc.
8. If possible, volunteer at the school for activities such as fund raisers, etc.

Parent's Role in their Children Career Choices

Several researches indicate that there are many factors that contribute to the holistic and healthy development of a child. One significant factor is education. Parents' involvement has far-reaching effects on a child's academic performance. How can parents contribute in their children's education? Here are some of the ways:

Ways to help your child choose a career path

- 1) Help your adolescent identify their skills, interests, and preferences with future career goals.
 - 2) Have open and honest discussions around potential career options and look for opportunities to foster career awareness.
 - 3) Encourage gaining experience and skills related to their occupational goals a priority.
 - 4) 'What do you love to do?' and 'what do you do well?' are two questions to get the conversation started. As a parent, it can be tempting to answer these questions *for* our kids, but it's important to have them verbalize it.
 - 5) Give them autonomy and encourage them to voice their opinion in the career conversation by asking questions and then truly listening to their responses.
- Remember that a meaningful career conversation is a "conversation"—"not a lecture".



Activity 3.8 Exploring career awareness through movies (15 minutes)

Objectives:

This activity will help participants to discuss career choices with children and explore different career paths together.

Resources:

- Sticky notes
- Pens
- Whiteboard

Activity steps and Instructions:

1. Ask participants to form a circle
2. Then ask them about their favorite movie and their favorite character's professions
3. Discuss aspects of the movie that might relate to them and their children aspirations.
4. Ask them if the movie influence their views on careers, in any way?
 - Did it depict certain occupations in a positive light or in a negative light?
 - Did the profession in the movie make them think or say, 'This is what, I want to do for a living!?' and why?
 - Observe character traits and discuss which ones you saw as positive and/or negative. What did you identify with and what did you feel dissociated from?

Learning Outcome:

After these activity participants will understand that how movies can shape children's career interests and aspirations, and how parents can use this medium to facilitate career discussions.

Notes for facilitators & follow-up actions by parents.

1. Create an open and supportive environment so that children can talk about their career interest and aspirations
2. Encourage children to explore different career paths without pressurizing or judging them.
3. Sit down with children and reflect on their career exploration journey

4. Discuss what they have learned, how their interest developed and what are their goals.
Help them to achieve those goals
5. Encourage participation in internships, volunteer opportunities for firsthand experience.
6. Arrange meetups for children at workplaces, to meet successful professionals and share success story with them.